

Gone in a Flash

Apple is hoarding almost all the flash memory being produced to meet expected demands

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Mitashi MWI-4GA

the music was playing and sibilance with some female vocals, particularly on the higher notes. The mid-range is sweet – clear, precise and with barely a hint of being recessed. The bass is punchy and extends pretty low.

Overall, the mid-range is where most of the action takes place and both these PMPs should be considered for classical and country music buffs where the mid-range and lower highs are really well rendered. While channel separation is good on both these PMPs, it's the Creative Zen Stone that gets the nod over the Shuffle for panning sounds. Therefore this player has a much more accurate and wider sound stage. However, for the sheer enjoyment or reproduction of most types of music, the iPod Shuffle is better than the Creative Zen Stone Plus.

Although it does not handle complex passages well and things get a little muddled at the top, the Philips GoGear SA2825 also did reasonably well. The bass is not as punchy as the leaders of the pack, neither is the mid-range well presented. Both the Mitashi players were not really bad. In particular, the MWI-4GA sounds good on its bundled earphones. The only disappointment was the absence of a 3.5-mm jack. The only issues we found on both these PMPs in terms of audio quality was that the bass, while boomy, was not focussed and rather slightly flabby. The mid-range was also recessed while the treble has a little extra sparkle that comes from an unfocussed top-end.

PMPs above Rs. 5,000: Sight with sound

When somebody spends upwards of Rs. 5,000 on a PMP, chances are they either have a good bit of cash to spend, or really

know exactly what they want. Obviously, there is no upper end to this category, save the one stipulation we had that each player had to be below a certain pre-defined size and weight limit. Therefore, larger, feature-rich and performance-heavy PMPs such as the iPod Touch and the iPod Classic, not to mention Cowon's excellent D2 and Q5W, were prevented from spoiling the minnows' party here.

We'll be testing larger PMPs, including video-based PMPs and the high-capacity, bulky hard drive-based offerings later this year, but we wanted to see if one could spend upwards of Rs. 5,000 and still get something that was relatively compact. We also wanted to see if there existed a large divide in terms of audio performance of PMPs across both categories.

It's difficult to define what someone buying a PMP for more than Rs. 5,000 expects for their money. To some, it may mean a large screen. To others, it may represent something that is sturdily built and does not compromise on audio quality one little bit. Obviously, style also matters and one expects a better grade finish, colour options, more memory and maybe some more functions such as an alarm, calendar, e-book reader and so on.

Someone shopping for a serious PMP would also look at storage size and the presence of expandable memory options. With the price of MMC/SD cards falling to throw-away values due to dirt-cheap flash memory prices, even 16 GB SD cards are now readily available and more affordable.

Features

If anything, all four test candidates in this category were similar to each other when compared to the cheaper PMPs. Apple's iPod Nano was the longest in terms of dimensions, but in its defence it is incred-

ibly slim. It's got a sleek contoured design and the sides are completely rounded.

In fact, the entire player is gently curved and even the screen is not flat but mildly concave. It has a crystal clear display, with very crisp text and video display capabilities, despite being all of two inches. The click wheel is typically Apple and works flawlessly with very even tracking. Menus are well laid out and the new Nano has an inbuilt accelerometer (gyroscope) meaning the display changes orientation according to the viewing angle.

The Sony NWZ-E436F is a very solid looking PMP as thin as the Nano. Its in-hand feel is even sturdier than the Nano, probably because it's smaller but also because it feels somehow denser in the hand. The finish is brushed aluminium and Sony has used some bright colours. The display of this unit is its highlight – it's amazingly clear and although measuring only two inches, text is very readable. Both these display units are said to use white-LED LCDs and the world of difference this makes to the colours and the contrast leads us to conclude that every manufacturer should dump the old CCFL LCD displays and jump on to the white-LED bandwagon.

Although the Sony NWZ-E436F's buttons are very small, they are ultra-usable and laid out really well. Even the tiny volume up / down buttons retain 100 per cent of their usability despite being half the size of those on the Mitashi MWI-4GA. If you have larger fingers, you'll have no ergonomic issues. Kudos to Sony's development teams for designing these devices so intelligently.

The other two players were from SanDisk. Fuze, from SanDisk, is square in



Sony NWZ-E436F